

AI and Democratic Power

Day 6A: Mechanisms, Interventions, and Unintended Consequences

Purpose. Move beyond a generic list of “risks to democracy.” Specify the capability or institutional change, the political mechanism it activates, the actors whose incentives change, and the intervention that targets that mechanism.

Mechanism Assignments

Each group selects or is assigned one:

1. **Information and manipulation:** synthetic media, persuasion, agenda control, or degraded common knowledge.
2. **Elite independence from citizens:** declining dependence on broad labor, skills, taxation, or mass consumption.
3. **Surveillance and administrative control:** expanded monitoring, classification, enforcement, and automated discretion.

Causal Chain

Complete every step. Avoid skipping directly from “AI exists” to “democracy declines.”

AI capability or institutional change
⇓
Change in information, resources, or dependence
⇓
Change in incentives or power of a named actor
⇓
Democratic consequence
⇓
Targeted policy intervention
⇓
Likely unintended consequence or abuse risk

Policy Design Requirements

Your intervention must identify:

- the institution with legal or practical authority to act;
- the regulated behavior, ownership structure, or capability;
- how compliance would be observed and enforced;
- who benefits and who bears the cost;
- how the policy itself could be captured, abused, or circumvented.

Three-Minute Briefing

Present the causal mechanism first and the policy second. Another team will identify the weakest causal link and the most serious unintended consequence.

Closing Comparison

Which mechanism can be addressed through content rules, which requires changing ownership or economic distribution, and which requires limits on state capacity itself?